

MADHUBANTI BAGCHI, 34
Singer
Mumbai

THE SHE LIST
UNDER 50

WOMAN TO WOMAN

"If I have any advice for other women, it's to develop a level of confidence, even delusion, up to a point. If you are really going to be somebody special, then you need to stop being practical"

THE **ARTISTS**

The Chart Topper

How does someone with a master's degree in engineering, a self-confessed introvert who does music for herself first and foremost, become one of the most sought-after voices in Hindi cinema? In Madhubanti Bagchi's own words: by "dreaming crazy". The credo is time-tested. "In 2016, after a phase of not taking up any singing projects, I suddenly got a call from M.M. Keeravani. I initially thought it was a prank call," she says. "I recorded the song in Hyderabad. The film never released but, coming back, I felt the moment had to mean something. I decided I was moving to Mumbai to pursue a career."

That journey began with umpteen jingles before her first chart-topper, 'Aaj Ki Raat' for *Stree 2*, and Bagchi has built an enviable catalogue of songs in the two years since. She has become the bonafide queen of foot-tapping tracks that can light up house parties as well as set a stage on fire, and there is no better testament to her skills than the fact that her songs seem tailor-made for her. She has reached a place where she can afford to call a spade a spade: it's still industry practice to not pay artists for recording film tracks.

"Seniors never raised their voice or felt the need to ask for money because they had enough," she says. "The situation becomes skewed and you are made to feel like 'I am doing you a favour by giving you this great opportunity that will change your life'." Bagchi admits she cannot bring about a sudden revolution in the system, but she'd rather bow out of an unfair situation and work with composers "who have respect for artists".

She is also selective about the songs she lends her voice to. "It sounds a little arrogant, but I really can't bear to think daily 'Oh my god, I need to get a hit ASAP and for that I will have to make, like, 15 calls to people'," she says. "Or that if I say no to this, then XYZ will not work with me or I won't have work." The belief in her abilities has helped her avoid the rat race. "I would put a lot of pressure on myself and not be able to do my best if I crowded my catalogue and sang way more," she adds. It makes her an anomaly in the music industry, but she'd rather be that than a recognisable clone. ■

— Suhani Singh

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Madhubanti has been unshakable at the top of Bollywood charts through hits in 2025 and 2026, with earworms in films like *Dhurandhar* and *Azaad*, and the recent *O'Romeo*